– generalised[4] throughout the planet. The chapter thus attempts to capture the changes in capitalism in its imperialist form, by addressing its economic dimensions without neglecting the social, political, cultural and ideological transformations integral to it. The gigantic scope of contemporary capitalism involves new and growing contradictions in almost all dimensions of social life.

The usual dominant periodisation has an obvious centric-capitalist profile besides transmitting openly or subtly North American and European values (Eurocentrism). It presupposes a bonanza post-war period that is guaranteed by international institutions despite difficulties attributed to the Cold War. Around the 1970s, a period of crisis erupts with different outlines: economic (the end of the Bretton Woods agreements and the oil crisis), social (May 1968) and military (the US defeat in Vietnam). Despite the reduced role of labour and the new financial dominance,[5] this periodisation assumes that neoliberalism will be the response to these crises as the successor to the welfare state that has reached its limits. The death of the Soviet Union strengthened the new 'Pax Americana', which sometimes considered the US as the unique superpower, at other times as a member of a 'Triad' together with Europe and Japan.

We propose a periodisation that does not ignore these elements but is defined by different benchmarks. In our view, the period 1945–1960, more than a bonanza, corresponds to imperialism's adjustment and expansion under conditions both constructed voluntarily and the result of unplanned situations. In the period significant alterations occur, beginning with the formidable quantum leap of capitalist concentration in the productive sector and worker formation (primary and secondary expropriations and the socialisation of the work process) and in the main organisational structure of politics. Capital-imperialism is therefore capitalist expansion now completely alienated from imperialism inasmuch as its expansion has reached previously unknown proportions and, therefore, needs to face different levels of contradictions.

After the inter-imperialist military devastation generated by World War II, the characteristic that up until then marked centre states' power politics, two new types of obstacles to the continuity of the previous mould were erected: the persistence and even expansion of the former Soviet Union and the use of the nuclear bomb in 1945, the United States' prerogative for only a while because in 1949 the Soviet Union detonated its first atomic weapon. The Cold War period began.

Even if the capitalist leaders' intentions had still been filled with imperialist attitude, as Lenin brilliantly and succinctly portrayed, through open or nuanced forms of territorial control over the periphery and through pacification of